

Yemen After the Red Sea Breakthrough

The Makkah Pact, Iran's Dual-Chokepoint Position and Türkiye's Escalation Risk

Power & Corridors x NERAI Foresight Desk | 13 September 2026 | Horizon: 3–12 months

MARITIME & POLITICAL-MILITARY RISK

MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE

CORRECTED EDITION
v2

BOTTOM LINE

- [VERIFIED]** Two chokepoints, two different mechanisms. The Strait of Hormuz has been closed since early March 2026 — Iranian closure, mining, a U.S.-led naval campaign, 100+ mines cleared by late August. NERAI's corridor layer reads **−92.2%** against baseline: that is the measurement of a closure, not of a threat. Bab el-Mandeb is the opposite case — still open, running **−21.0%**, and now coercible from the Yemeni coast. Treating them as one lever is the most common analytical error in this file.
- [VERIFIED]** The week's decisive event was not in Yemen. On 11–12 September drones launched from Maysan province in Iraq struck Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline and Riyadh shut the 1,200 km Abqaiq-Yanbu line — 4–5 million barrels a day, the kingdom's only way of reaching tidewater without Hormuz. Not a Houthi operation, and the single most consequential development of the period for Saudi exposure.
- [NERAI]** Saudi Arabia is now closed on both export geometries at once. That, more than the battlefield, is what converts the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement from a declaratory instrument into a working one — and what makes a Turkish contribution more likely, not less.

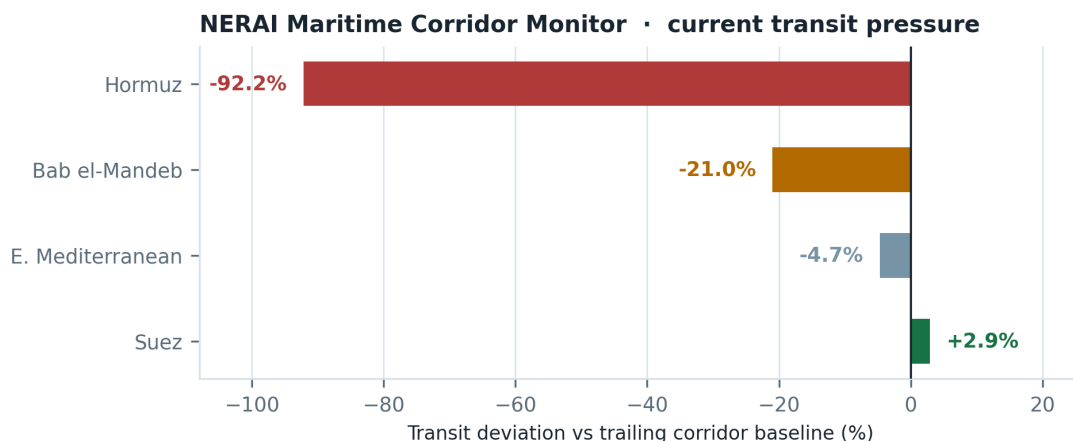
WHY THE HOUSHI ADVANCE HAPPENED WHEN IT DID

This was a counter-move, not an opening move. On 8 September Yemeni government forces launched an offensive and publicly committed to retaking Sanaa. It stalled, then unravelled: Mocha fell on 10–11 September, Perim/Mayyun on 12 September. Saudi Arabia backed the effort with a heavy air campaign — the Houthis claim 129 raids in 48 hours by F-15 and Typhoon aircraft, unacknowledged by Riyadh — and it still failed, because eight nominally allied armies with a split command cannot convert air superiority into held ground. Occupying the coast is not the same as controlling the strait; several outlets have used the word “control”, and NERAI does not.

THE SCORE, AND WHAT IT IS

HORMUZ TRANSIT vs BASELINE	PETROLINE SHUT 11-12 SEP	TÜRKİYE-IRAN CLASH · 12M
−92.2%	4-5 mb/d	8% → 45%
closed since early March 2026	Saudi Arabia's only Hormuz bypass	no deployment → deployment + U.S. surge

Corridor figures are NERAI platform data measured against corridor-specific trailing baselines. The Türkiye-Iran band is a structured analyst estimate, not raw model output: 8% over 12 months with no Turkish deployment, ~12% with intelligence-sharing alone, ~25% with a persistent armed UAV/ISR presence, ~35% with an overt naval or air-defence deployment, and ~45% if such a deployment is already in place when Washington intensifies its Iran campaign after the 3 November midterms.



NERAI Maritime Corridor Monitor, as of 7 September 2026.

WHAT THE MAKKAH PACT ACTUALLY OBLIGES

[VERIFIED] Signed by Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan on 7 August 2026: an armed attack against any one of the three is to be regarded as an attack against all. On 31 August the first Strategic Political and Defence Committee met, the pact took effect, a permanent secretariat was fixed in Riyadh and the first secretary-general was designated to be Pakistani. [INFERENCE] Institutionalisation has begun; force generation has not. Pakistan's 10 September statement that no military response has yet been discussed is not evidence the pact is empty — it is evidence that it is being read as a graduated-response mechanism. A secretariat in Riyadh with a Pakistani secretary-general gives Saudi Arabia the venue and Pakistan the procedural brake.

WILL TÜRKİYE INTERVENE?

[NERAI] Probably at the support layer; probably not as a ground combatant. Ankara's incentives favour contributions that visibly support Saudi defence while keeping Turkish casualties and political ownership limited: intelligence and ISR first (65% at 3 months, 80% at 12 if attacks persist), air-defence reinforcement and naval escort next (12% → 40%), covert technical support in between (18% → 35%), and a Turkish ground campaign in Yemen last. [NERAI] One trigger is unusually specific in NERAI's own signal framework: routine counter-PKK operations in Iraq and Syria are explicitly *not* treated as a major escalation signal, but the deployment of Turkish unmanned systems to a **new** theatre is. A SİHA/IHA appearing over the Red Sea or western Saudi Arabia would therefore be a different event from intelligence-sharing conducted from existing Turkish facilities.

THE REAL RISK IS SEQUENCING, NOT INTENT

Türkiye does not need to choose a war with Iran for a confrontation to emerge. The dangerous order is: Riyadh invokes the pact after another strike on its infrastructure → Turkish ISR, air-defence or naval assets enter the theatre → Washington expands operations against Iran after the midterms → Turkish personnel and platforms are suddenly inside an active Iran-aligned battlespace, exposed to a retaliation chain they did not initiate. Physical exposure, not intent, is what changes the risk regime.

SCENARIOS TO MARCH 2027

SCENARIO A

45%

Controlled collective defence. Türkiye provides ISR, air defence or naval support; Pakistan provides diplomatic and planning cover; no direct Iran-Türkiye clash.

SCENARIO B

25%

Proxy confrontation. Iran-aligned actors raise costs for Turkish interests in Iraq and Syria once Ankara's support for Riyadh becomes visible.

SCENARIO C

15%

Maritime entanglement. Turkish naval or support assets become targets during simultaneous Houthi and Iranian escalation — low frequency, high consequence.

SCENARIO D

10%

Multi-front Türkiye-Iran confrontation. A Red Sea incident combines with Iraq/Syria proxy pressure and post-midterm U.S. escalation. Tail risk; requires multiple triggers.

SCENARIO E

5%

Rapid diplomatic containment. The pact is used mainly for deterrence while Oman and Pakistan reduce Hormuz/Red Sea pressure. Possible, but the least likely near-term path.

Estimates are analyst judgments conditioned on the situation as of 13 September 2026 and sum to 100%.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED

7 AUGUST 2026

The Makkah Joint Defence Agreement is signed

[VERIFIED] Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan agree that an armed attack on one is an attack on all. The first Strategic Political and Defence Committee follows on 31 August; the pact enters into effect, with a permanent secretariat in Riyadh and a Pakistani first secretary-general.

8 SEPTEMBER 2026

73 wounded in Saudi Arabia — and a counter-offensive that fails

[VERIFIED] The Saudi-led coalition reports 73 people wounded in Houthi attacks on Saudi civilian and energy sites, with fires and halted operations. The same day, Yemeni government forces launch a counter-offensive and vow to retake Sanaa.

10-12 SEPTEMBER 2026

Mocha, Dhubab, Perim/Mayyun

[VERIFIED] The offensive collapses and the coast follows. Houthi forces take Mocha, enter Dhubab and reach Mayyun (Perim) Island at the mouth of Bab el-Mandeb. [NERAI] The effect is surveillance, launch geometry and coercive credibility — not legal or uncontested control of the strait.

11-12 SEPTEMBER 2026

Saudi Arabia loses its Hormuz bypass

[VERIFIED] Drones launched from Maysan province in Iraq strike the East-West pipeline; Riyadh shuts the Abqaiq-Yanbu line carrying 4-5 million barrels a day, roughly 4-5% of global supply. No group claims responsibility; analysts point to Iran-aligned armed groups in Iraq. Brent trades above \$104.

11 SEPTEMBER 2026

Washington declines

[VERIFIED] Trump declines the Saudi crown prince's request for direct U.S. strikes on the Houthis (first reported by Axios, subsequently carried by Reuters). He says separately that he does not regret the Iran war and that it "ends right after the election". [INFERENCE] The refusal is the clearest signal that Washington intends regional partners to carry more of Red Sea defence — which is precisely what raises the probability of a Turkish contribution.

WHAT WOULD CHANGE THIS

- A formal Saudi invocation of the pact after another high-casualty attack — or a second strike on export infrastructure — is the most likely single trigger, and it is now more likely to come from an energy target than from the Yemen front.
- Turkish unmanned systems appearing over the Red Sea or western Saudi Arabia. Under NERA's own trigger logic that is a change of theatre, not a continuation of existing operations.
- Post-midterm expansion of U.S. strikes on IRGC naval, missile or command targets while Turkish assets are already deployed — the sequence that moves the conditional estimate to ~45%.
- On the downside: repair and reopening of the East-West pipeline without repeat strikes from Iraqi territory, and any material recovery in Hormuz transit, would both lower the whole ladder.

METHOD AND LIMITS

Claims are labelled: [VERIFIED] rests on an official publication or named-outlet reporting carrying its date; [NERAI] is proprietary platform output — indices rank each series against its own history and are not cross-country military-power scores, and corridor readings compare current activity with corridor-specific trailing baselines; [INFERENCE] is analyst judgement drawn from the two. Scenario and intervention probabilities are structured analyst estimates, not direct model outputs; their derivation is published in the full analyst version. This corrected edition (v2) was fact-checked line by line against primary sources.

SOURCES

1. Saudi Press Agency / MFA Pakistan / MFA Türkiye — Makkah Al-Mukarramah Summit for Joint Defence, 7 Aug 2026; Strategic Political and Defence Committee joint statement, 31 Aug 2026.
2. Reuters, 10 Sep 2026 — Pakistan says no military response discussed under the Mecca pact.
3. Al Jazeera / NPR / Arab News / The National, 8 Sep 2026 — 73 wounded in Houthi attacks on Saudi civilian and energy sites; Al Jazeera, 8 and 13 Sep 2026 — the Yemeni counter-offensive and its collapse.
4. CNN, NPR, Euronews, NBC News, 10-12 Sep 2026 — Mocha, Dhubab and Mayyun/Perim.
5. CNBC and Al Jazeera, 11-12 Sep 2026 — East-West (Abqaiq-Yanbu) pipeline shut after drone attacks launched from Maysan province, Iraq.
6. Axios, 11 Sep 2026 (carried by Reuters) — Trump declines Saudi request for strikes on the Houthis; Arab News/Reuters, 11 Sep 2026 — 'it ends right after the election'; Reuters/Al-Monitor, 2 Sep 2026 — attacks may intensify after November.
7. NERA's risk-intelligence platform — corridor monitor (7 Sep 2026), country-topic indices and 12-month forecasts (13 Sep 2026), Forecast Desk (11-13 Sep 2026). This briefing is informational and is not financial, legal or investment advice.